

Cybersecurity Incident Response Plan

Leadership, technical response, communications, legal, insurance, and recovery responsibilities

OWNER Chief Technology Officer / Cybersecurity Coordinator	DISTRICT Ardent ISD	REVIEW CYCLE Annual + after major incident	POLICY CROSS- REFERENCE CQB FL records-retention procedures
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Training Sample - Customize Before Use. This document is an instructional artifact for Ardent ISD. It should be aligned to current board policy, administrative procedures, cyber-insurance requirements, records-retention requirements, and advice of district legal counsel before operational use. Legal and reporting requirements can change.

1. Purpose

Ardent ISD uses this plan to coordinate a disciplined response to cybersecurity incidents that could disrupt district operations, compromise student or employee information, or damage public trust. The plan is intentionally cross-functional. Cybersecurity incidents are not handled by Technology Services alone.

The district's response objectives are to:

1. protect students, staff, and district operations;
2. contain the incident without destroying evidence;
3. preserve reliable facts for technical, legal, insurance, and law-enforcement review;
4. meet applicable reporting and notification obligations;
5. restore critical services in a controlled order; and
6. document lessons learned and reduce recurrence.

2. Governance and Authority

The Superintendent designates the **Chief Technology Officer as Ardent ISD's Cybersecurity Coordinator**. The coordinator activates this plan when an event may meet the district's incident threshold. Texas Education Code §11.175 requires a district cybersecurity policy, a designated cybersecurity coordinator, and reporting/parent notice in specified student-information incidents. Texas reporting also intersects with Texas Cyber Command requirements and Texas Business & Commerce Code Chapter 521. Legal counsel determines the district's legal obligations in a specific event.

Core Incident Leadership Team

Role	Primary responsibility during incident
Superintendent - Dr. Elena Ramirez	Executive authority; board coordination; continuity decisions
CTO / Cybersecurity Coordinator - Morgan Lee	Incident lead; technical coordination; state cyber reporting liaison
District General Counsel	Privilege strategy; legal analysis; notification obligations; law-enforcement coordination
Chief Communications Officer - Avery Brooks	Internal/external communications; family/media messaging; rumor control
CFO / Risk Management - Priya Shah	Cyber-insurance notice; financial controls; emergency procurement
Chief HR Officer - Cameron Ortiz	Employee impact; workforce communication; identity protection coordination
Student Services / Privacy Lead	Student-record impact; family support; FERPA/Texas student privacy coordination
Records Management Officer	Legal hold, records preservation, public-information coordination
External IR / Forensics	Evidence collection, scoping, containment and recovery support as authorized

Backups and contact information are maintained in a protected offline contact sheet. At least two members of the incident team shall have access when district systems are unavailable.

3. Incident Severity Levels

Level	Description	Typical examples	Activation
1 - Event	Suspicious activity with no confirmed compromise or material disruption	blocked phishing attempt; malware quarantined on one device	Technology Services handles; document as needed
2 - Limited Incident	Confirmed compromise with contained scope and limited operational/data impact	compromised user account; lost encrypted device; small unauthorized disclosure	CTO activates limited team; counsel notified when protected data may be involved
3 - Major Incident	Significant compromise, protected-data exposure, multi-system impact, or material service disruption	ransomware in one business system; admin-account takeover; vendor breach affecting district data	Full incident team; insurer and external IR considered immediately
4 - Crisis	Districtwide or safety/continuity impact; widespread data exposure; active extortion	enterprise ransomware; SIS/ERP outage during critical operations; large exfiltration	Superintendent-led crisis structure; full continuity and communications plan

Severity may increase or decrease as evidence changes.

4. Activation and First Actions

When a suspected incident is reported:

1. **Open an incident record** using Artifact 3, *Cyber Incident Intake and Triage Form*.
2. **Validate and scope** before declaring facts. Preserve logs, messages, alerts, and relevant system state.

3. **Contain without destroying evidence.** Isolate affected accounts, devices, or segments as appropriate; avoid wiping or reimaging until the incident lead/forensics team authorizes it.
4. **Protect backups and privileged access.** Confirm backup isolation and review administrative-account activity.
5. **Notify the incident leadership team** based on severity.
6. **Contact cyber insurer/breach counsel** according to policy before retaining outside vendors when coverage terms require it.
7. **Start the legal/reporting clock log** using Artifact 4. Document *discovery*, *determination*, *eradication*, *closure*, and *recovery* dates separately.
8. **Establish a source of truth.** Technical facts go to the incident lead; public-facing facts go through Communications and legal review.

Do not: wipe affected systems, destroy logs, negotiate with an extortion actor, promise that “no data was accessed,” or send public notices before facts and legal obligations have been reviewed.

5. Response Lifecycle

A. Detect and Analyze

- Confirm whether the alert is an event, incident, or suspected breach.
- Identify affected systems, identities, data sets, campuses, vendors, and business processes.
- Determine earliest known malicious activity and likely initial access.
- Determine whether privileged accounts, backups, student records, employee records, financial systems, safety systems, or communications platforms are affected.
- Create an evidence register with source, collector, date/time, and storage location.
- Use NIST CSF 2.0 as a shared vocabulary: **Govern, Identify, Protect, Detect, Respond, Recover.**

B. Contain

Containment decisions should balance stopping harm against preserving evidence and maintaining school operations. Examples include disabling compromised accounts, revoking sessions/tokens, blocking indicators, isolating devices or VLANs, limiting vendor connectivity, and temporarily disabling high-risk integrations.

C. Eradicate

Remove malicious persistence, reset credentials in a controlled sequence, patch exploited vulnerabilities, rotate keys/tokens, remove unauthorized applications, and validate that attacker access has been removed.

D. Recover

Prioritize recovery based on learning and operational impact:

1. identity, authentication, DNS, core network and security controls;
2. safety, communications, payroll/finance and student information systems;
3. instructional platforms and campus services;
4. lower-priority services.

Restored systems should be monitored for recurrence. Backups must be tested before restoration and scanned/validated before being trusted.

E. Close and Improve

Closure requires technical recovery **and** leadership closure. The team documents:

- what happened and what remains uncertain;
- what data/systems were affected;
- all notifications and reports made;
- recovery milestones and residual risk;
- costs and insurance activity;
- control failures and corrective actions;
- policy/procedure changes;
- lessons for the next tabletop exercise.

Update Artifact 11, *Cybersecurity Risk Register and Improvement Plan*.

6. Reporting and Notification

Use Artifact 4 for the operational decision flow. As of this library's August 2026 review:

- Texas Cyber Command states that the same statutory incident-reporting deadlines apply to school districts and charter schools: reporting within **48 hours of discovery** when the incident is reportable, with reporting within 24 hours strongly encouraged, and a follow-up analysis by the **10th business day after eradication, closure, and recovery**.
- Texas Education Code §11.175 requires district reporting as soon as practicable for specified cyberattacks/cybersecurity incidents constituting a breach of system security and requires parental notice when the reportable incident involves a student's information.
- Texas Business & Commerce Code §521.053 can require notice to affected individuals without unreasonable delay and generally no later than the **60th day after the district determines that the breach occurred**; if at least **250 Texas residents** are involved, electronic notice to the Texas Attorney General is required as soon as practicable and no later than the **30th day after determination**.

District General Counsel validates which statutes, contracts, insurance provisions, and federal privacy rules apply to the facts of each incident.

7. Communications Rules

- Communications owns public messaging; Technology Services provides verified technical facts.
- Use an initial holding statement when facts are incomplete.
- State what is known, what is being investigated, what stakeholders need to do, and when the next update will occur.
- Do not speculate about threat actor identity, ransom amount, data exfiltration, or root cause.
- Use Artifact 8, *Cyber Incident Communications Packet*.

8. Vendor Incidents

When a vendor reports an incident:

- obtain incident number, discovery date/time, data types, affected records, attack window, controls involved, containment status, and expected update cadence;
- preserve the vendor's notification and contract/DPA;
- determine whether the vendor is the data owner or merely maintains district data for purposes of Texas notice obligations;
- review contractual notification timelines and cooperation requirements;
- consider disabling integrations or credentials until risk is understood;
- do not assume the vendor's statement resolves Ardent ISD's independent legal duties.

9. Exercises and Maintenance

Ardent ISD will conduct at least one cross-functional tabletop exercise annually and after major changes to identity, backup, SIS/ERP, network, or incident-response vendors. The plan is reviewed annually and after every Level 3 or Level 4 incident.

Suggested exercise evidence:

- 24/48-hour checklist completion;
- contact-tree test;
- sample TXCC/OAG decision matrix;
- draft board/family communication;
- restore test from protected backup;
- after-action report with assigned remediation owners.

Related Artifacts

- Artifact 2 - First 24/48 Hours Cyber Incident Checklist
- Artifact 3 - Cyber Incident Intake and Triage Form
- Artifact 4 - Texas Cyber Incident Reporting and Breach Notification Decision Matrix
- Artifact 7 - Cyber Incident Executive Brief
- Artifact 8 - Cyber Incident Communications Packet
- Artifact 9 - Cybersecurity Incident Quick Runbooks
- Artifact 11 - Cybersecurity Risk Register and Improvement Plan

Authority and Reference Notes

- Texas Education Code § 11.175 - School Cybersecurity
- Texas Government Code Chapter 2063 - Texas Cyber Command (see § 2063.302)
- Texas Business & Commerce Code Chapter 521 - Identity Theft Enforcement and Protection Act
- Texas Cyber Command - Report a Cybersecurity Incident
- TASB - School Cybersecurity: Texas Requirements

- TASB - School Cybersecurity: Security Breach Notification and Response
- NIST Cybersecurity Framework 2.0
- CISA - Protecting Our Future: Cybersecurity for K-12
- CISA - #StopRansomware Guide
- U.S. Department of Education - Data Breach Response Checklist
- K12 SIX - Cybersecurity Essentials Series and Incident Response Runbook